

But the Tibetans didn’t want to change. Their religion—Buddhism—taught nonviolence, which meant that most Tibetans believed in peace, not in fighting. Some Tibetans did try to fight back against the invading PLA. But their soldiers were no match for China’s army. The PLA made its way across Tibet, moving closer to Lhasa.

Tibet’s government officials were worried. They needed to have a strong leader to unite the country against the Chinese. They wondered if the Dalai Lama was ready to take on his role as Tibet’s political leader. The Dalai Lama was nervous, too. He was only fifteen years old. But one of the wise religious leaders said, “His time has come.” So on November 17, 1950, the teenage lama was given full responsibility to lead Tibet.

Six months later, the Chinese government forced the Tibetan government to sign an agreement saying that Tibet was a part of China. The document said that the Chinese were still going to allow Tibet to govern itself. The Dalai Lama hoped the agreement would stop the violence of the PLA against his people.